Civil–military separation is so deep that the training programme of Indian Foreign Service probationers does not include training in military affairs. There is no arrangement for specialization of at least some foreign service officers in military affairs even at a later stage in their career. ‘India’s approach to international politico-military problems has generally been based on a political and even ethical assessment,’ wrote one observer in 1970, adding that it was ‘largely divorced from any objective understanding and evaluation of the military and technical implications of a given situation’.[52] This imbalance favouring political platitudes over hard-nosed politico-military analysis has continued.

The uniformed services have demanded for years that India should create an organizational set-up similar to that of the American joint chiefs of staff. The latest government committee to recommend this was the Naresh Chandra task force on defence in 2012.[53] Critics argue that keeping the uniformed military out of policymaking and strategic thinking has resulted in a situation where the uniformed military does not really know how to make policy if it were asked to do so. India’s generals are said to have no clue about foreign policy because they have been marginalized by the civilians. Instead of working a way out of that marginalization, the military has embraced it and remains unaware of events and decision making outside its immediate sphere.

The Indian Navy is the only service that has been proactive on strategic issues. Starting around 2004, the navy produced a naval doctrine in addition to preparing analyses on maritime security, countering piracy and protecting India’s sea lanes of communication (SLoCs). The navy has also built ties with navies of other countries including the US and the Gulf regions. In the words of a former diplomat ‘the navy has muscled its way into the foreign policy realm’, possibly because it is by nature outward-looking. It will, however, take more than the Indian Navy’s efforts to integrate uniformed services in formulation of foreign policy.